Immediately thereafter, China enthusiastically participated in the negotiations on the Comprehensive Test Ban Treaty (CTBT). China was well aware that there were three threshold countries, but only one, India, represented a concern for them. Seeing a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity to permanently cripple the Indian nuclear programme, China played its part in ensuring that India's concerns over the CTBT were kept outside the purview of consultations. China's Ambassador for Disarmament, Sha Zukang, later said that there were no negotiations with India because it was none of their business. India, he said, chose to keep a distance. However, China also saw to it that, officially, there were no mechanisms or arrangements for the nuclear weapons states to understand India's position. [11] The outcome of the CTBT negotiations represented a triumph for China. It placed her firmly inside the nuclear club, aligned to the Americans and other nuclear-weapon states, and kept India outside, without the possibility of future nuclear assistance from any of the nuclear powers. China presumed that it had closed the loop as it were; they did not expect India to politically defy the international community.

When India tested three nuclear devices in Pokhran on 11 May 1998, the initial Chinese reaction was muted. They expressed 'grave concern' and proclaimed that India's nuclear testing 'runs against the international trend'. [12] After the second set of tests on 13 May, though, the Chinese response was very sharp. Their statement used strong language like 'deeply shocked' and 'strong condemnation'. China also urged the international community to adopt a common position in demanding that India stop further development of nuclear weapons. The clue to this drastic change in the Chinese stance came towards the very end of their statement, which said, 'It has maliciously accused China of posing a nuclear threat to India. This is utterly groundless.' [13] They had of course, by then,